

Recursive Functions and Memoization

1 Recursive Functions

- computing Fibonacci numbers
- an exponential number of function calls

2 Memoization

- storing results of function calls
- using a dictionary

MCS 320 Lecture 20
Introduction to Symbolic Computation
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computing Fibonacci numbers

The Fibonacci numbers $F(n)$ are defined as

$$F(0) = 0, \quad F(1) = 1, \quad n > 1 : F(n) = F(n-1) + F(n-2).$$

This definition leads to a natural recursive function:

```
def F(n):  
    if n == 0:  
        return 0  
    elif n == 1:  
        return 1  
    else  
        return F(n-1) + F(n-2)
```

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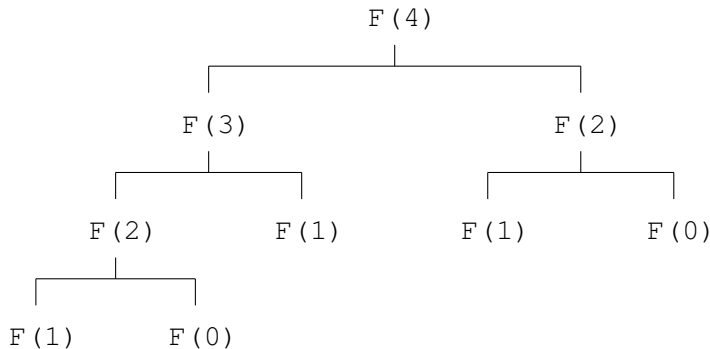
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an exponential number of function calls



Let c_n be the number of calls to compute $F(n)$.

- Consider some base cases: $c_2 = 2$, $c_3 = 4 = 2^2$, $c_4 = 8 = 2^3$.
- Recursion: $c_n = c_{n-1} + c_{n-2} + 2 = \dots$ is $O(2^n)$.

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storing results of function calls

Definition (memoization)

Memoization is a technique to improve the performance of programs by storing the results of function calls.

Applied to the Fibonacci numbers, the list

$$L = [0, 1, 1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 13, 21, 34]$$

stores the first 10 Fibonacci numbers, $F(n) = L[n]$.

Two steps in a memoized computation of the n -th Fibonacci number:

- 1 Before computing $F(n)$, return $L[n]$ if it exists.
- 2 After computing a new $F(n)$, store $F(n)$ as $L[n]$.

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using a dictionary

```
def memoizedF(n, D={}):  
    """  
    All calls made to memoizedF are stored in D.  
    """  
    if n in D:                # dictionary lookup  
        return D[n]  
    else:  
        if n == 0:  
            result = 0  
        elif n == 1:  
            result = 1  
        else:  
            result = memoizedF(n-1) + memoizedF(n-2)  
        D[n] = result        # store the result in D  
    return result
```